

Day 3 — Outcome-Based Planning vs Output-Based Tracking

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: wire **tracking** on top of yesterday's ADO backlog so the team sees both outputs (work shipped) and outcomes (impact produced) — and surfaces failure early. Draft DP §3.

Where we are in the week

The outcome map exists (Day 1). The backlog is loaded (Day 2). Today builds the **tracking plan** that pairs every output with an outcome metric AND a leading indicator. Without this, the team ships features and never learns whether they worked.

Inputs

- DP §1 (outcome map)
- DP §2 (loaded ADO)
- Tier Sheet from Week 2
- TCD §4 (SLOs and error budgets)
- TMD §5 (baselines + monitoring plan)

Why most tracking plans fail

FAILURE	SYMPTOM
Output-only	"We shipped 12 stories this sprint." Nobody asks if anything moved.
Lagging-only	The first time you know the feature failed is when retention drops 90 days later.
Vanity-only	DAU went up. (But nobody knows from what — push notifications? promotions?)
No counter-metric	The metric moved up; nobody noticed it moved up <i>the wrong way</i> (gaming).
Dashboard-without-action	Beautiful charts; no decisions ever change.

A mature tracking plan avoids all five. The discipline:

- Every output has an outcome
- Every outcome has a leading indicator
- Every metric has a counter-metric (or an explicit "no" with rationale)
- Every dashboard has a **decision** it informs

The output / outcome / leading-indicator triple

For every meaningful output, the tracking plan has three rows:

OUTPUT (WHAT SHIPPED)	OUTCOME (WHAT CHANGED FOR USERS / BUSINESS)	LEADING INDICATOR (THE EARLY SIGNAL)
Reconcile mobile flow	Median reconcile time per dispatcher drops 45→12 min	Reconcile-flow first-attempt completion ≥ 80% by week 2
Auto-suggest top 5 tickets	Time-to-select drops 30s→10s	% of dispatchers using suggestion ≥ 50% by week 4
Manager view dashboard (deferred)	(n/a — out of scope)	(n/a)

The **leading indicator** is the muscle. Without it, the team waits 30 days to learn the outcome failed. With it, they know within a week whether the trend is right.

The tracking cadence (today's mental model)

Tracking is wasted unless someone looks at it on a regular rhythm:

CADENCE	AUDIENCE	WHAT'S REVIEWED
Daily	Engineers / on-call	Alerts, error budget, immediate breaks
Sprint (2 weeks)	Triad + eng lead	Output velocity, leading indicators trending right?
Monthly	TPM + PM director	Outcome metrics — is the feature winning?
Quarterly	Triad + leadership	NS movement, KPI roll-up, the big picture

If a metric has no cadence, it has no audience. If a metric has an audience but no cadence, it's reviewed when there's a fire — too late.

Activity 1 — Output / Outcome / Leading-Indicator Triples

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Build the central tracking table — every meaningful output paired with an outcome and a leading indicator.

Triad protocol

1. **List the outputs** (10 min). Pull from DP §2 — the User Stories that produce user-visible behavior. Aim for 5–8 outputs (not all stories produce distinct outcomes).
2. **For each output, name the outcome** (10 min). Use DP §1's outcome map. Several outputs may share an outcome — that's fine.
3. **For each outcome, name the leading indicator** (10 min). The earliest signal you'd watch.
4. **Sanity-check** (5 min). Is each leading indicator measurable within 7 days of launch?

Sample triple table — FieldPulse

OUTPUT	OUTCOME	LEADING INDICATOR
Reconcile mobile flow shipped	Median reconcile time 45→12 min in 30d	First-attempt completion ≥ 80% by week 2
Idempotent submission	Submission error rate < 0.1%	Duplicate-submit rate < 0.5% in week 1
Audit event publishing	SOC 2 audit passes Q3 review	Event volume + DLQ depth steady through week 4
Inline error states + recovery	Customer support tickets about reconcile drop 50%	Tickets per dispatcher per week declining starting week 3
WCAG AA conformance	Zero accessibility complaints in 90 days	axe-core scan pass rate 100% on every PR from week 1

What "good" looks like

- Each triple is **specific**, not "we'll watch some metrics"
- Leading indicators are **measurable within 7 days**
- Outcomes are user-visible (not output dressed up)
- Counter-metrics are referenced (from NS Defense Card)

Activity 2 — Sprint-Level Tracking (the 2-week loop)

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Design the sprint review where outputs and outcomes are inspected together.

The sprint-review structure

A typical sprint review covers:

1. **What shipped** (outputs) — pull from "Done in this sprint" query
2. **What's still open** — pull from "Open in current sprint" query
3. **Velocity** — points completed
4. **Leading indicators** — which moved? Which didn't?
5. **Anomalies** — unusual patterns from the week
6. **Adjustments for next sprint** — what to do differently

The TPM-owned twist: **at least one slide / segment is about outcome**, not output. The team sees the leading indicators next to the velocity.

Triad protocol

1. **Design the sprint review template** (15 min). 6 sections, with content per section.
2. **Decide the cadence anchor** (5 min). Day of week; time; recurring.
3. **Build the "leading indicator dashboard"** (15 min). What charts go on it? Each chart references one or more leading indicators from Activity 1.
4. **Identify the alarm** (5 min). For each leading indicator: at what threshold do we say "this isn't moving — what should we change next sprint"?

What "good" looks like

- Sprint review template has a **slot for outcome**, not just output
- The leading indicator dashboard has **3–5 charts** (more = ignored)
- Each chart has a **threshold** that triggers a specific conversation

Activity 3 — Monthly + Quarterly Tracking

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Design the monthly outcome review and the quarterly NS roll-up.

Monthly outcome review

The monthly review answers: **is the feature winning?**

Structure:

```
## Monthly Outcome Review – <feature>

### The primary outcome
Baseline: <X>
Current: <Y>
Target by <date>: <Z>
Status:  /  / 

### Supporting outcomes
[same table]

### Counter-outcomes (the guardrails)
[same table]

### What we learned this month
<2–3 bullets – what surprised us, what changed our model>

### Decisions for next month
<3–5 specific decisions: invest more / pivot / stop>
```

The "What we learned" + "Decisions for next month" sections are what make the review **actionable** rather than ceremonial.

Quarterly NS roll-up

The quarterly review answers: **did the feature contribute to the NS?**

- Did the primary outcome move?
- Did the supporting outcomes contribute?
- Did counter-outcomes stay flat?
- Did the NS itself move? (Often hard to attribute to one feature; that's fine — name what you can.)

Triad protocol

1. **Monthly review template** (15 min). Customize the structure above for your feature.
2. **Quarterly roll-up template** (15 min). Same.

3. **Identify the **author + audience** for each (5 min). Who writes? Who reads?
4. **Identify the **cadence anchor** (5 min). First Tuesday of every month? Day after sprint? Pick.

What "good" looks like

- Monthly review template has **decisions** as a non-skippable section
- Quarterly roll-up explicitly **attributes (or de-attributes)** outcome movement
- Author + audience are **named** — not "the team"
- Cadence is **calendar-anchored**, not "monthly-ish"

Activity 4 — Build the Tracking Plan + AI Pattern Detection

Format: Triad • 45 min + Wrap • Block 4

Purpose

Combine Activities 1–3 into a single tracking plan section of the DP. Add the AI-pattern-detection prompt that helps spot anomalies.

DP §3 structure

```
## 3. Tracking plan

### Output / Outcome / Leading-Indicator triples
[Activity 1 table]

### Counter-metrics
[from NS Defense Card]

### Sprint-level tracking
- Cadence: <day, time, frequency>
- Template: <link>
- Leading indicator dashboard: <link>
- Thresholds + actions: <table>

### Monthly outcome review
- Cadence: <day, time, frequency>
- Template: <link>
- Author / audience: <names>

### Quarterly NS roll-up
- Cadence: <day, frequency>
- Template: <link>

### AI pattern detection
- Prompt: <link to Pattern Library entry>
- Frequency: weekly / per sprint review
- Validation: cross-check against ADO query results
```

The AI pattern-detection prompt

```
Role: Senior PM doing pattern detection across a sprint's work.
Context: <ADO query results – items shipped, items blocked,
        leading indicator readings>
Task: Identify the top 3 patterns:
  1. A leading indicator moving the wrong direction (or flat
     when expected to move)
  2. A category of work over- or under-represented in this sprint
  3. An anomaly worth investigating (specific stories /
     timing / volume)
Constraints:
  - Use only the data provided
  - For each pattern, name the specific items / numbers
  - Suggest one investigation step per pattern
Format: 3 numbered patterns; each with: pattern / evidence / suggested investigation.
```

Triad protocol

1. **Combine into §3** (15 min). All four sections.
2. **Run the AI prompt** on a synthetic sprint (10 min).
3. **Validate** (10 min). Cross-check claims.
4. **Cross-review with another triad** (10 min). The reviewer asks: is each leading indicator measurable within 7 days?

Wrap (last 15 min)

Each triad shares:

- One **leading indicator** they're proudest of
- One **anomaly** they expect to see in the first sprint
- One **decision** they imagine making in the first monthly review

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad ends Day 3 with:

- ✓ Output/outcome/leading-indicator triples (5–8 outputs)
- ✓ **Sprint-level review template** + cadence + dashboard
- ✓ **Monthly outcome review template** with named author + audience
- ✓ **Quarterly NS roll-up template**
- ✓ AI pattern-detection prompt + provenance
- ✓ DP §3 drafted